

**ASSESSMENT OF EFFECTIVENESS OF ONLINE VENDOR PLATFORMS IN
PROMOTING MICRO-BUSINESS PERFORMANCE OF TECHNOLOGY AND
VOCATIONAL EDUCATION STUDENTS IN UNIVERSITIES IN EBONYI STATE**

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Abstract

The study assessed the effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting micro-business performance of Technology and Vocational Education (TVE) students in universities in Ebonyi State. Descriptive survey research design was used in the study. Two research questions guided the study, and two hypotheses were tested at 0.05 level of significance. A sample size of 150 students of TVE in 2024/2025 academic session from the two universities in Ebonyi State was used. The sampled students were micro-business owners who were actively selling their products or services using online platforms. A structured questionnaire validated by two experts in Vocational and Technical Education department and one of the experts, from Measurement and Evaluation unit, AE_FUNAI was used in the study. Trial testing method and Cronbach Alpha analysis was used to determine reliability, which yielded 0.98, and 0.85 and its overall reliability of 0.88 indicates that the instrument was reliable. The questionnaire was sent electronically to students whatsapp groups and data collected was analyzed using mean and standard deviation for research questions, and t-test analysis for hypotheses testing. The result revealed that online vendor platforms are highly effective in promoting revenue growth and meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State, as it helps to acquire more customers and make profits. In conclusion, students should use personalized communication, social media interaction and loyalty programs to bring strong relationship with customers. The researchers therefore recommend that institutions and organizations should promote access to digital tools and resources to facilitate e-commerce of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Keywords: Online Vendor, Online Platforms, Micro-Businesses, Micro-Business Performance

Introduction

The rapid growth of e-commerce and proliferation of online marketplaces have created new opportunities for micro-entrepreneurs to reach out to wider audiences and expand businesses. Digitalization and E-commerce have ushered in a new era of entrepreneurship, where online platforms have become the primary marketplace for many small businesses (Ratten, 2020). Vendors have embraced these opportunities by using digital tools and channels to overcome geographic and resource constraints that have traditionally limited the growth of micro-enterprises in the society. Nevertheless, micro-business owners could as well use these digital platforms to sell products and services, overcoming traditional barriers of geographic limitations and resource constraints facing micro-businesses. (Bacigalupo *et al.*, 2016).

Meanwhile, the act of buying and selling using digital platforms could be referred as e-commerce. Furthermore, Ocloo *et al.* (2020) stated that E-commerce involves the act of buying and selling of products and services via internet. E-commerce allows business owners to grow businesses more easily in global markets and opens more opportunity for enterprises to transfer information to consumers, suppliers, and other stakeholders (Thuy,

2022). E-commerce speeds up ordering, delivery, and payment of goods and services. It lowers company's operational and inventory cost, replacing manual and paper-based operations with electronic equivalents and exploit information flow in innovative and dynamic ways. Thus, E-commerce is a potential contributor to growth and development of micro-business.

Micro-businesses can be defined as an enterprise that comprised less than 10 employees which play a vital role in local and regional economy, contributing to job creation, innovation, and community development (Eggers, 2022). Most at times, micro-business operations face significant challenges especially in building brand awareness, reaching new customers, selling products and scaling in activities. Consequently, online vendor came as potential agents that can transform micro-businesses particularly in Nigeria (Chaffey and Ellis-Chadwick, 2019). They could expand customer base, improve operational efficiency and enhance overall performance of businesses using online platforms. The effectiveness of online vendor platforms needs to be well understood in promoting micro-businesses performance. This is because Homburg and Giering (2019) stated that micro-businesses are important contributors to local economy as it provides employment

opportunities, supports community development and promote access to local products particularly in emerging markets.

Despite many contributions made by authors on factors affecting online businesses such as digital marketing strategies, website design, and customer engagement, there is no strong empirical evidence on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting entrepreneurship and performance of micro-enterprises (Roundy, 2017). This dynamic is crucial, as students with adequate educational background, unique skills and knowledge, ability, resources and networks find it difficult to effectively use online platforms for business growth (Laudon and Traver, 2021). In support of the above, it is observed that students who have opportunities to nurture successful implementation of business models fail in their businesses.

Consequently, online vendor platforms came to assist students gain valuable insights on electronic development, entrepreneurship programs and provide support services to help online vendors sell or buy products. Online vendor platforms involve the use of social media platforms for marketing activities to improve performance. It can be seen that a wider number of people around the globe are now on social media (Chaffy, 2020), and adoption of these platforms as a

strategy for improving micro-business performance is a matter of necessity. Many advertisements in form of videos, pictures and graphics are often displayed on social media platforms for targeted users. The users of these platforms can display preferred brands for customers to buy on social media platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, WhatsApp, YouTube, among others (Laudon and Traver, 2021). With these procedures, it reduces cost on advertisements, promotes brands awareness and increases interaction with business owners and customers. In this regard, online vendor platforms have become a lather in the world of digital marketing as it effects performance of micro- businesses (Alonso and ogle, 2018).

Online vendor platform is a potential platform that employ strategies for creating better awareness, increase market coverage, increase competitiveness, improve business customer relationship and foster information sharing (Alonso and ogle, 2018). In support of the statement, Eggers (2020) stated that online vendor platforms are tools that SMEs use to increase brand awareness through engaging customers at different levels and location. It is very crucial for business survival and growth. Similarly, online vendor platforms have played a significant role in marketplaces

by carving out a distinctive brand identity and securing a loyal customer base (Peacock, Stewart and Belcourt, 2020). It provides a highly competitive landscape enabling online vendors to reach out to global customers and compete with others in the field (Laudon and Traver, 2021). Meanwhile, the growth of online platforms has undoubtedly created new avenues of entrepreneurship for online vendors and micro-business performance.

Notwithstanding, these online vendor platforms have many challenges that even those with adequate educational background are limited in their ability to achieve sustainable growth and success in businesses (Chaffy, 2020). For example, factors such as web design, search engine optimization, digital marketing and data analytics have significantly hindered the performance of online vendors in micro-businesses (Kumar and Singh, 2019). Similarly, another important factor that affects micro-business performance are financial and operational constraints which characterized micro-businesses. Additionally, lack of business resources, such as working capital, inventory management systems, and infrastructure, to effectively scale operational needs and meet the demands of an online customer greatly affect the performance of micro-businesses (Quinton and Simkin, 2017). Thus, the gap between the promise of

digital entrepreneurship and realities of micro-business performance has raised many concerns (Apavaloaei, 2016). Therefore, adoption of online vendor platforms such as social media platforms could significantly improve or impede the performance of micro-businesses.

Business performance comprises of sales, profitability, return on investment, rate of turnover and gain on market share. However, literatures showed quantitative and qualitative indicators that limit many businesses (Laudon and Traver, 2021). In quantitative measures such as Return on Investment (ROI), profit, sales, and so on limit businesses, whereas, qualitative measures often called performance indicators such as knowledge and business experience, ability to offer quality products and services, capacity to develop new products and processes, ability to manage and work in groups, labour productivity and corporate responsibility to environment often affect businesses. In line with the above statement, Kuratko (2017) measured the performance of small and medium enterprises with reference to three aspects; namely profitability, productivity, and market. The Author came up to say that these indicators can promote or retard businesses. Additionally, Peacock, Stewart and Belcourt (2020) stated that performance effort represented by growth venture consist of sales growth,

growth of company's assets, and profit growth. Factors such as changing consumer preferences, technological disruptions, and evolving policy and regulatory environments have significant impact on viability and success of micro-businesses (Quinton and Simkin, 2017).

Furthermore, as students often juggle academic responsibilities with entrepreneurial ambitions, online vendor platforms could provide a flexible and cost-effective solution that could allow them reach a wider audience without the burden of traditional storefronts. These platforms can facilitate targeted marketing and data-driven decision-making, empowering student to optimize their offerings and connect more effectively with consumers. Hence, effective revenue growth and high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State need to be encouraged by using media such as personalized communication, social media interaction, and loyalty programs to ensure that students achieve strong relationships with customers.

Statement of the Problem

The growth and performance of micro-business are critical factors for economic development and job creation in Ebonyi State. In recent years, rise in online vendor platforms like Etsy, Shopify, social

media and Amazon in marketplace have opened new opportunities for TVE students in universities to start and grow micro- businesses. Existing research on micro-business performance has primarily focused on traditional brick-and-mortar businesses, highlighting factors such as owner's characteristics, resource constraints and overall business ecosystem as factors affecting micro- business (Audretsch *et al*, 2020). Hence, it is imperative to assess the effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting performance and growth of micro-businesses of technology and vocational education (TVE) students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Research questions

The following research questions guided the study.

1. How effective is online vendor platforms in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State?
2. How effective is online vendor platforms in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State?

Hypotheses

The following hypotheses were tested at 0.05 level of significance:

1. There is no statistically significance difference in mean responses of male and female students on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.
2. There is no statistically significance difference in mean responses of male and female students on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Methodology

The study assessed the effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting micro-business performance of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. Descriptive survey design was used in the study. Nworgu (2015) defined descriptive survey design as a research method used to gather information about the status, characteristics, or opinions of a specific population or group. It describes and summarizes the data collected without manipulating any variables. The researchers employed survey research design because it involves the use of questionnaires, combining both quantitative and qualitative elements to

provide a comprehensive understanding of the constructs under investigation. The use of descriptive design is extremely effective in collecting information from a large number of respondents within relatively short time. The area of study was Ebonyi State which was chosen for this research purpose because, majority of TVE students in universities are engaging in online micro -businesses using online vendor platforms.

In addition, 150 TVE students comprised the population of the study, which were purposively sampled from students of Alex Ekwueme Federal University, Ndufu Alike (AE-FUNAI) and Ebonyi State University, Abakaliki (EBSU) in 2024/2025 academic session. The sampled students were micro-business owners who were actively selling their products or services using online platforms. A structured questionnaire with 16 item statements, validated by two experts from the Department of Vocational and Technical Education and one expert from Measurement and Evaluation unit, AE_FUNAI formed the instrument of the study. Trial testing method was used to determine the reliability in which the instrument was administered to 20 TVE students at Enugu State University of Science and Technology (ESUT) and data was collected. The collected data was analyzed using Cronbach alpha which

yielded 0.98, and 0.85, with the overall reliability of 0.88. All alpha values exceeded the minimum benchmark of 0.88, indicating that the items for each construct were reliably measuring the intended variables. Data collection was done using online questionnaire (Google Forms) that was shared electronically to whatsapp groups of TVE students in the two universities in Ebonyi State. Ethical considerations such as voluntary participation, anonymity, and confidentiality were strictly observed, with respondents assured that the information provided would be used solely for academic purposes. 150 online questionnaires were successfully received and recorded.

Descriptive statistics of mean and standard deviation were used to answer the research questions, while inferential statistics of t-Test was employed in testing hypotheses. These analytical methods were selected to determine influence of independent variables on the dependent variable. If the calculated t-value (t-cal) is greater than or equal to the critical t-value (t-crit) and the significance level (p-value) is less than or equal to 0.05, reject the null hypothesis (H_0). Conversely, if the t-cal is less than t-crit or the p-value is greater than 0.05, fail to reject the null hypothesis (H_0), meaning no significant difference exists between the groups.

Results

- 1. How effective is online vendor platforms in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.**

Table 1: Mean and Standard Deviation on Effectiveness of Online Vendor Platforms in Promoting Revenue Growth of Micro-Businesses of TVE Students in Universities in Ebonyi State.

S/N	Item Statement	X	SD	Remarks
1.	Online platforms increased my business revenue consistently over the years	4.11	1.02	Agreed
2.	The adoption of online sales contributed significantly in my business revenue.	3.75	0.90	Agreed
3.	There is a steady rise in revenue due to expansion of my customer base.	3.95	0.91	Agreed
4.	Seasonal sale spike has positively impacted my business revenue.	3.75	0.85	Agreed
5.	Global exposure and new market access increased my business revenue.	3.81	0.91	Agreed
6.	Diverse products/services offered online increased my revenue	3.65	0.82	Agreed
7.	I invest more into online business due to recent revenue growth.	3.75	0.79	Agreed
8.	I spend less in advertising and promotion due to online sales	3.78	0.86	Agreed
	Grand Mean	3.81	0.89	Agreed

The analysis of data in table 1 showed that all the respondents agreed on all the items. The items have mean scores of 4.11, 3.75, 3.95, 3.75, 3.81, 3.65, 3.75 and 3.78 with their standard deviations respectively for item 1-8. This shows that online vendor platforms can significantly help micro-business to increase revenue growth using global exposure as a result of offering more diverse products/services

online. The grand mean of 3.81 which is slightly above mean bench mark indicates that students use online vendor platforms to promote revenue growth of micro-businesses. This implies that online vendor platforms are effective in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Hypothesis 1 Testing

Table 2: t-test Analysis of Male and Female Respondents on effectiveness of Online Vendor Platforms in Promoting Revenue Growth of Micro-Businesses of TVE Students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Gender	N	Mean	Std. Deviation	t-value	df	Sig. (2-tailed)	t-cal	t-crit (0.05)	Decision on H ₀
Male	72	3.67	0.52	1.76	145	0.046	0.98	1.97	Accepted
Female	78	3.78	0.68						

Source: Authors Computation 2026, N = number of respondents.

The mean scores of males (3.67) and female (3.78) respondents show a slight difference, with females rating higher. The t-calculated value (0.98) is less than the t-critical value (1.97) at 0.05 level of significance. Also, the p-value (0.046) is less than 0.05, indicating no significance

difference in mean responses of male and female students on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. This implies that online vendor platforms promote revenue growth of micro-businesses.

2. How effective is online vendor platforms in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Table 3: Mean and Standard Deviation on effectiveness of Online Vendor Platforms in Meeting High Market Reach of Micro-Businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

S/N	Item Statement	X	SD	Remarks
9.	Online platforms have successfully expanded my business market reach beyond my local area.	3.75	0.93	Agreed
10.	Online platforms have helped me reach customers from different geographic regions.	3.65	0.80	Agreed
11.	My business can serve a wider people than it did previously.	3.91	0.60	Agreed
12.	I receive orders from customers in locations I couldn't have reached.	3.85	1.10	Agreed
13.	My market reach has grown due to increased visibility through online advertising and promotion.	3.75	0.90	Agreed
14.	I have an increased visibility of my business through online advertising and promotion.	3.75	0.60	Agreed
15.	I handle customers' inquiries and complains outside my immediate community.	3.65	1.05	Agreed
16.	Online platforms help in easy delivery of products and services.	3.85	1.10	Agreed
	Grand Mean	3.77	0.85	Agreed

The analysis of data in table 3 showed that all the respondents agreed on all the items. The items have mean scores of 3.75, 3.65, 3.91, 3.85, 3.75, 3.75, 3.65, and 3.85 with their standard deviations respectively for item 9 -16. The grand mean of 3.77 which is above the mean bench mark indicates that online vendor platforms can increase brand visibility,

help business owner to reach customers from different geographic regions, handle customer's inquiry and complains which are very effective in meeting high market reach of micro- business. It implies that online vendor platforms are highly effective in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Hypothesis 2 Testing

Table 4: t-test Analysis of Male and Female Respondents on Effectiveness of Online Vendor Platforms in Meeting High Market Reach of Micro-Businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State.

Gender	N	Mean	Std. Deviation	t-value	df	Sig. (2-tailed)	t-cal	t-crit (0.05)	Decision on H ₀
Male	72	3.58	0.67	2.08	145	0.044	0.96	1.95	Accepted
Female	78	3.74	0.68						

Source: Authors Computation 2026, N = number of respondents.

The mean scores of males (3.58) and females (3.74) are close, but test result shows a t-calculated value (0.96) compared with t-critical (1.95). Although the mean difference is marginal, the p-value (0.044) is less than 0.05, suggesting no statistically significance difference in mean responses of male and female students on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. This indicates that online vendor platforms are highly effective in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State

Discussion

The finding of the study showed that online vendor platforms are effective in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. This is because, all respondents agreed that online vendor platforms are effective on revenue growth

of micro-business. The finding was supported by the hypothesis testing which stated that there was no statistically significant difference in male and female students' mean responses on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting revenue growth of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. The t-test highlights that both genders have agreed that online vendor platforms promote revenue growth of micro-businesses. In support of the above statement, Peacock, Stewart and Belcourt (2020) opined that online vendors are highly effective in increasing sales and revenue through a combination of broader market access, operational efficiencies, targeted marketing, and enhanced customer engagement. It implies that online vendor platforms are highly effective in achieving extensive market reach through global accessibility, diverse offerings, scalable marketing strategies, social media engagement, data-driven insights, partnerships, customer

relationship management, and mobile optimization (Alonso and ogle, 2018). Hence, students can create digital tools and strategies by compelling shopping experience for repeat purchases, ultimately contributing to long-term financial success. It highlights how these platforms significantly enhance business operations of student entrepreneurs. It provides access to broader market, and enable students reach diverse customer beyond their local areas (Kuratko, 2017). This increased accessibility, combined with reduced operational costs associated with physical storefronts, allows for greater efficiency and competitive pricing in micro-businesses. Additionally, the ability to gather and analyze customer insights informs better decision-making regarding inventory and product offerings which directly or indirectly enhance micro-business (Chaffey and Ellis-Chadwick, 2019).

Additionally, the finding of the study revealed that online vendor platforms are effective in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. This is because, respondents agreed on all items stating that online vendor platforms are effective and are geared towards high market reach. The finding was supported by hypothesis testing which revealed that there was no statistically significant

difference in male and female students' mean responses on effectiveness of online vendor platforms in meeting high market reach of micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State. This finding conformed to the finding of Ratten (2020) who stated that online platform significantly and positively affects the financial performance as measured by turnover, profit, and return on asset (ROA). The online platforms allow micro-businesses to leverage digital marketing tools to reach specific demographic segments more effectively. It enables micro-business owner to tailor messaging and product offerings to targeted audience (Laudon and Traver, 2021). Online vendor platforms facilitate collection and analysis of customer data, enabling micro-business owner gain valuable insights. This helps them tailor their product/service recommendations and create a more personalized shopping experience, which can improve customer satisfaction and loyalty. The convenience of 24/7 online shopping caters for consumers, while targeted marketing strategies help tailor promotions based on customer data, improving engagement and sales conversion (Ocloo *et al.* 2020). The study emphasized the importance of customer engagement, as direct interaction through feedback, as social media fosters loyalty and encourages repeat purchases.

Additionally, online vendor platforms are highly effective for micro-businesses of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State, as it promotes sales, customer relationships, and long-term business success.

Conclusion

Digital technology and online platforms have transformed the landscape of entrepreneurship, particularly for micro-businesses owners. Online vendor platforms have emerged as vital tools to assist TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State to navigate the challenges of starting and managing businesses. This is because online vendor platforms are highly effective in enhancing sales, customer relationship, and long-term business success as seen in this study. The study explored various dimensions such as market accessibility and revenue growth of micro-businesses. Therefore, this research has contributed in examining the success of micro-businesses done by TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State using online vendor platforms.

Implications of the Study

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Assessment of effectiveness of online vendor platforms in promoting micro-business performance of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State has emphasized the importance of technology adoption among student entrepreneurs in universities. The findings emphasized the transformative potential of online vendor platforms in supporting student entrepreneurship, as it provides insights into consumer preferences and behaviors in online marketplaces, which can be valuable for business success.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of the study, the researchers therefore recommend that:

1. Institutions and organizations should promote access to digital tools and resources that could facilitate e-commerce of TVE students in universities in Ebonyi State
2. Students should be encouraged to adopt sustainable business practices, such as eco-friendly sourcing of finance and packaging of goods.

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